

Henry Lunt Song Introduction: by Clive Romney

From Henry Lunt's journal:

"November 1st, 1852, Ellen and I took a walk and looked at the lot I had selected on the plot for the city. We found it was rather broken up, having a hollow running through it and some large rocks on it.

"I was well satisfied with it, knowing that no one would envy us of it, and they could not say that we had chosen one of the best lots.

"I hauled many loads of adobes and rock before we could even begin building a foundation for our home."

Henry Lunt was unselfish to the core, and totally without pretense. His sole aim was to build Zion. But he also had a sense of humor:

At Christmas, the same year, Henry journaled:

"About six o'clock the meeting house was crowded with brethren and sisters ready for dancing. My wife and I attended the party.

"After dancing a little while, the room became so densely crowded that it was impossible to dance with any degree of pleasure, in consequence of which I preached a little and called upon others to do so.

"I invited the brethren to make a contribution of provisions for to give to the Indians and to take it to the Bishop. . . . "After some time preaching, the room became a little... thinned...and we commenced dancing again."

Henry's father, Randle Lunt, a land-owning gentleman farmer, died in 1836 when Henry was 12 years old.

But before he passed away Randle said to his wife in Henry's presence, "I have my doubts as to the Church of England being the true church."

He also said on several occasions that he hoped that some of his children would someday find the true gospel.

In 1849, at age 25. Henry heard the restored gospel preached, and he was baptized on October 6 of that year. Just three months and four days later on January 10, 1850 Henry left for Zion.

He arrived in Salt Lake City on August 28 of the same year. Since he was single and had no family responsibilities, he began helping others to harvest their produce and crops.

Henry answered a call for volunteers to go to Cedar City and form the Iron Mission to mine and process iron ore. Henry could read and write very well. So, he was appointed President George A. Smith's private secretary and assistant clerk of the wagon train.

On January 13th, 1850, the settlers arrived in Parowan.

Though Henry received property equal to every other family unit, he did not build a home for himself since he was single, but instead put all his labor toward fencing and other community projects, and to helping others.

Late November of 1851 John Whitaker brought his family, which included his wife, Mary, and his daughter, Ellen, into Parowan. Henry was immediately attracted to Ellen.

Four months later, on March 25, 1852, Henry Lunt and Ellen Whitaker married in Parowan. They returned the same day to Coal Creek (now Cedar City) where they would initially live in a wagon box taken off its running gears.

Six weeks later, Wednesday, May 12, 1852, Brigham Young organized Parowan and Cedar City into the Iron County Stake of Zion. Henry was called and sustained as second counselor to Stake President John Calvin L. Smith.

November 11th of 1852, Henry wrote, "It has been twelve months this day since I first came down to this place (Coal Creek) with eleven wagons for to commence a settlement. It was then a wild desert but is now a fruitful field. "The work that has been accomplished...is a miracle - by a small number of men, not many more than thirty."

In 1854 Henry proposed establishing schools to teach the young people, among other things, the Paiute language and to teach the Paiute children the English language and other skills. There were to be day, evening, and night schools.

In July of the same year (1854) Henry answered the call to serve a mission to England for three years. Thirty years later, when Henry was mostly blind, Henry served another mission to England, this time with his first wife, Ellen, accompanying him.

Upon his return from England in 1857, Henry married Mary Ann Wilson as his second wife on October 7th of that year. Mary Ann bore him eight children.

In December of 1859, Henry Lunt, now age 35, was sustained simultaneously as Stake President and as Bishop of Cedar City.

Three years later, on 11 April 1863 Henry married his third wife, Ann Gower, who bore Henry ten children.

December 19, 1874, Henry Lunt, now age 50 and mostly blind, was called as Patriarch of the Parowan Stake. He still continued to serve as bishop of the Cedar Ward.

On 16 January 1878, Henry married his 4th wife, Sarah Ann Lunt, who bore him eight children.

The persecutions that attended the passage of the Edmunds-Tucker act in 1887 forced Henry to go into hiding, and finally, in 1890, into Mexico, where he died twelve years later from skin cancer.

This song is dedicated to Henry Lunt, the visionary man who became blind, but never lost sight of what Zion could be.